

D314

Essentials of Academic Writing

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A nurse is citing a 2021 article by Lopez, Chen, and Ward in her scholarly paper on fall prevention. The article appeared in a journal with a high impact factor and runs 14 pages. What is the correct APA 7 parenthetical citation the first time she cites it?

- A. (Lopez et al.)
- B. (Lopez et al., 2021, p. 14)
- C. (Lopez, Chen, & Ward, 2021)
- D. (Lopez et al., 2021)

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A source has exactly two authors, Patel and Kim, published in 2020. How is it cited in parentheses in APA 7?

- A. (Patel et al., 2020)
- B. (Patel and Kim 2020)
- C. (Patel & Kim, 2020)
- D. (Patel, 2020)

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

While drafting her paper at 11 p.m., a student rewrites a paragraph from a hospital report in completely new words and changes the sentence order. The report was published by a well-known health system. Does she need to cite it?

- A. Yes; a paraphrase uses someone else's ideas and must be cited.
- B. Only if she uses quotation marks.
- C. No; rewording the text makes it her own work.
- D. No, because well-known organizations are common knowledge.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A nurse wants the strongest evidence for hourly rounding to reduce falls. Her unit manager, who has 25 years of experience, strongly favors rounding. Which source should she rely on most?

- A. A systematic review and meta-analysis of randomized controlled trials on hourly rounding.
- B. The unit manager's expert opinion.
- C. A single cohort study at one hospital.
- D. A national survey of nurses' preferences.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which source provides the lowest level of evidence for whether an intervention works?

- A. A randomized controlled trial.
- B. A case-control study.
- C. A meta-analysis of RCTs.
- D. An editorial giving an expert committee's opinion.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A student finds an article in which the authors enrolled 240 patients, randomized them to two wound-care methods, and measured healing time. The article was shared widely on a nursing forum. What type of source is it?

- A. A secondary source, because it is published in a journal.
- B. A primary source reporting original research.
- C. A secondary source, because it was shared on a forum.
- D. A tertiary source such as an encyclopedia.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A nurse writing a scholarly paper about her med-surg unit, which has 32 beds, drafts four thesis options. Which is the strongest thesis?

- A. A 32-bed unit is the ideal size for any hospital.
- B. This paper will discuss shift report.
- C. Bedside shift report improves patient safety on medical-surgical units and should replace hallway report.
- D. Nurses give shift report every day.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A nurse on a busy orthopedic unit asks: In adults after hip replacement, does early walking within 24 hours, compared with walking on day two, reduce length of stay during the hospital admission? The unit uses a new electronic scheduling system. In this PICOT question, what is the outcome?

- A. The electronic scheduling system
- B. Early walking within 24 hours
- C. Length of stay
- D. Adults after hip replacement

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

In the question “In teens with type 1 diabetes, does a texting reminder program, compared with usual care, improve A1C over six months?” which element is the comparison?

- A. A1C
- B. Six months
- C. A texting reminder program
- D. Usual care

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A student is choosing sources on nurse burnout. Her search engine's top result is a blog post with 50,000 shares. Which source is the best choice for a scholarly paper?

- A. A 2023 peer-reviewed study in a nursing journal that reports its methods.
- B. Any source that ranks first in search results.
- C. The widely shared blog post.
- D. A 1998 textbook chapter.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A study of a new hand-hygiene program at three urban hospitals reports a relative risk of infection of 0.80 with a 95% confidence interval of 0.65 to 0.98. The program was funded by a state grant. What can the student conclude?

- A. The program proves infections will always drop 20% anywhere.
- B. The program was linked to a statistically significant 20% lower infection risk.
- C. The result is not significant because the interval is wide.
- D. The program raised infection risk by 80%.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A study reports an odds ratio of 0.85 for readmission with a 95% confidence interval of 0.70 to 1.04. Was the intervention effective?

- A. Yes, it cut readmissions by 15%.
- B. The reduction was not statistically significant, because the interval includes 1.
- C. It proved the intervention has no effect.
- D. It increased readmission by 4%.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

A nurse is citing a 2021 article by Lopez, Chen, and Ward in her scholarly paper on fall prevention. ~~The article appeared in a journal with a high impact factor and runs 14 pages.~~ What is the correct APA 7 parenthetical citation the first time she cites it?

Target word: first citation, three authors **Decides:** Three or more authors use et al. from the first citation.

A	Dropped element	Leaves out the year.
B	Camouflage	Page count is not a pin cite; page numbers are for direct quotes.
C	Confusion set	Listing all three first was an older APA rule.
D	Correct	APA 7 uses et al. for three or more authors from the start.

2. Answer C Concept 1 • transfer

A source has exactly two authors, Patel and Kim, published in 2020. How is it cited in parentheses in APA 7?

Target word: two-author rule **Decides:** Two authors are always both named.

A	Inverted operation	Et al. is for three or more authors.
B	Dropped element	Missing the comma and uses and inside parentheses.
C	Correct	Both authors are named every time, joined by an ampersand in parentheses.
D	Absolute language	Treats the first author as the only author.

3. Answer A Concept 2

While drafting her paper ~~at 11 p.m.~~, a student rewrites a paragraph from a hospital report in completely new words and changes the sentence order. ~~The report was published by a well-known health system.~~ Does she need to cite it?

Target word: citation for paraphrase **Decides:** The idea still comes from the source.

A	Correct	Citations credit ideas, not just exact words.
B	Confusion set	Quotation marks are for exact words; both quotes and paraphrases need citations.
C	Inverted operation	Changing words does not change who had the idea.
D	Camouflage	The publisher's fame does not make its specific findings common knowledge.

4. Answer A Concept 3

A nurse wants the strongest evidence for hourly rounding to reduce falls. Her unit manager, ~~who has 25 years of experience,~~ strongly favors rounding. Which source should she rely on most?

Target word: highest level of evidence **Decides:** Meta-analysis of RCTs tops the hierarchy.

A	Correct	Pools multiple RCTs; highest level.
B	Camouflage	Experience does not raise expert opinion above research evidence.
C	Adjacent category	Observational; lower than RCT-based reviews.
D	Confusion set	Preferences are not outcome evidence.

5. Answer D Concept 3 · transfer

Which source provides the lowest level of evidence for whether an intervention works?

Target word: reverse: bottom of the hierarchy **Decides:** Expert opinion ranks lowest.

A	Inverted operation	RCTs are near the top.
B	Adjacent category	Observational but still above opinion.
C	Inverted operation	The highest level.
D	Correct	Opinion without systematic data is lowest.

6. Answer B Concept 4

A student finds an article in which the authors enrolled 240 patients, randomized them to two wound-care methods, and measured healing time. ~~The article was shared widely on a nursing forum.~~ What type of source is it?

Target word: primary or secondary **Decides:** The authors collected their own data.

A	Adjacent category	Journals publish both; the data origin decides.
B	Correct	Original data collected by the authors.
C	Camouflage	Where it was shared does not change what it is.
D	Confusion set	Tertiary sources compile summaries.

7. Answer C Concept 5

A nurse writing a scholarly paper about her med-surg unit, ~~which has 32 beds~~, drafts four thesis options. Which is the strongest thesis?

Target word: arguable, specific claim **Decides:** States a position the paper will support.

A	Camouflage	Built on the bed count, which is not the paper's focus.
B	Dropped element	Announces a topic without a claim.
C	Correct	Specific, arguable, and supportable with evidence.
D	Confusion set	A fact is not arguable.

8. Answer C Concept 6

A nurse on a busy orthopedic unit asks: In adults after hip replacement, does early walking within 24 hours, compared with walking on day two, reduce length of stay during the hospital admission? ~~The unit uses a new electronic scheduling system.~~ In this PICOT question, what is the outcome?

Target word: O in PICOT **Decides:** The result being measured.

A	Camouflage	Not part of the question.
B	Confusion set	That is the intervention.
C	Correct	The outcome is what is measured.
D	Adjacent category	That is the population.

9. Answer D Concept 6 · transfer

In the question “In teens with type 1 diabetes, does a texting reminder program, compared with usual care, improve A1C over six months?” which element is the comparison?

Target word: C in PICOT **Decides:** What the intervention is compared against.

A	Confusion set	That is the outcome.
B	Adjacent category	That is the time frame.
C	Inverted operation	That is the intervention being compared.
D	Correct	The comparison group.

10. Answer A Concept 7

A student is choosing sources on nurse burnout. Her search engine’s top result is a blog post ~~with 50,000 shares~~. Which source is the best choice for a scholarly paper?

Target word: credible scholarly source **Decides:** Current, peer-reviewed, with methods.

A	Correct	Current, peer-reviewed, and transparent.
B	Absolute language	Search rank is not quality.
C	Camouflage	Popularity is not credibility.
D	Adjacent category	Credible type but likely outdated for a current topic.

11. Answer B Concept 8

A study of a new hand-hygiene program ~~at three urban hospitals~~ reports a relative risk of infection of 0.80 with a 95% confidence interval of 0.65 to 0.98. ~~The program was funded by a state grant.~~ What can the student conclude?

Target word: was the effect significant **Decides:** The interval does not include 1.

A	Absolute language	One study cannot guarantee the effect in every setting.
B	Correct	RR 0.80 means 20% lower risk, and the CI excludes 1.
C	Adjacent category	Significance depends on whether 1 is inside the interval, not width alone.
D	Inverted operation	RR below 1 means lower risk.

12. Answer B Concept 8 · transfer

A study reports an odds ratio of 0.85 for readmission with a 95% confidence interval of 0.70 to 1.04. Was the intervention effective?

Target word: reverse: interval crosses 1 **Decides:** 1.0 lies inside the interval.

A	Dropped element	Reads the point estimate and ignores the interval.
B	Correct	An interval containing 1 is consistent with no effect.
C	Absolute language	Non-significance means not shown, not proven zero.
D	Wrong stem number	Reads the upper limit as the result.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owled.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	4	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	1	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	7	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	6	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	4	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	7	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	7	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	APA in-text citation	APA 7 uses author surname and year; for three or more authors use the first author plus et al. from the first citation.	Listing all authors the first time or leaving out the year.	A source with a given number of authors and a citation format question.
2	Paraphrase still needs a citation	Putting another author's idea in your own words still requires an in-text citation; only common knowledge and your own ideas go uncited.	Believing rewording removes the need to cite.	A writer changed the words but kept the source's idea.
3	Levels of evidence	Systematic reviews and meta-analyses of randomized controlled trials rank highest; single RCTs next; then cohort/case-control; expert opinion ranks lowest.	Ranking a respected expert's opinion or a large survey above an RCT.	Choosing the strongest source to support an intervention.
4	Primary vs. secondary sources	A primary research article reports original data collected by its authors; a secondary source summarizes or interprets others' work.	Calling a review article or textbook a primary source.	Whether the authors collected the data themselves.
5	Thesis statement	A thesis states a specific, arguable claim the paper will support with evidence.	Writing a topic announcement or a plain fact as the thesis.	Picking the best thesis for a scholarly paper.
6	PICOT question	Population, Intervention, Comparison, Outcome, Time frame structure a searchable clinical question.	Mixing up the intervention and the outcome.	A clinical question to be broken into parts.
7	Evaluating scholarly sources	Prefer current, peer-reviewed sources by qualified authors that report methods; popularity or web ranking does not establish credibility.	Trusting a source because it is popular or widely shared.	Choosing among candidate sources for a scholarly paper.
8	Judging whether an intervention worked	A result is statistically significant when the 95% confidence interval for a ratio excludes 1 (or $p < .05$); significance alone does not prove the effect is large or important.	Calling any reduction a success even when the interval crosses 1.	A relative risk or odds ratio with a confidence interval.

Course scope (public description): The learner will explore professional communication by applying the principles of academic writing to their discipline. Learners will incorporate these skills into the development of an evidence-based scholarly paper in their specialty area. As learners develop a scholarly paper, they will acquire a deeper understanding of the research topic selected and analyze whether initiatives and interventions have been effective or ineffective.